

SPORTS

No Boxing Her In

*As she keeps succeeding in the ring, boxer **Nikhat Zareen** is also busy changing mindsets outside of it*



In the middle of our interview, Nikhat Zareen talks about how she recently wrote a list of 10 things she wanted to eat after the Asian Games trials. "Butter naan, butter chicken, rumali roti, chicken 65, schezwan vada pav, pani puri, momos, pasta," she rattles off. Having now secured her spot at the Asian Games (51kg category) and also the IBA Women's World Boxing Championship (52kg), Zareen, 25, has a small window in which she can enjoy all of Delhi's finest fast food. In no time, the flyweight boxing champion will be switching back to a diet of chicken, salads, rotis, and intense training sessions twice a day.

For Zareen, 2022 has begun with a bang. After recovering from Covid in January, she won her second gold medal at the 73rd Strandja Memorial Boxing Tournament in Bulgaria last month. She recalls with relish how she beat Tokyo Olympic silver medalist Buse Naz Çakıroğlu, who had defeated her at the Bosphorus Tournament in Turkey last year. "It was sweet revenge," she says.

Zareen says she now likes to confuse her opponents by not looking them in the eye. "I look at their gloves...they won't be able to understand what is going on in my mind." Her mantra is to remain calm and composed, without losing her aggressive edge. Opponents, she says, once won games against her by clinching, holding and throwing punches while she did nothing: "That gave the judges the impression that I am weak. Now if any boxer tries to hold me, I give it back, tit for tat." Right now, Zareen has her sights trained on the Paris Olympics 2024. "I imagine myself standing on the podium at the Paris Olympics with the gold medal," she says. "The mind is everything—what you think will happen."

Known as 'Bushra' to friends and family in Nizamabad, Zareen says her successes in the boxing ring have led to changes outside of it. "At first, people used to ask my father why I'm boxing in spite of being a girl. They would say no one will marry me if my face gets ruined. Now, they call my parents and ask, 'When is Bushra coming? Bring her home'. It is nice to see I have at least changed people's mentality." Sport, it is clear, has afforded Zareen a rare freedom: "I'm lucky to live this life because where I come from, young women are already married with at least three kids. I am grateful I live life to the fullest." ■

–Anu Prabhakar

After her many wins in 2022, 25-year-old boxer **NIKHAT ZAREEN** is being looked at as a successor to Mary Kom



ON REEL
Shreyas Talpade in *Kaun Pravin Tambe?*

Q. Has the IPL been a boon for cricketers, as your story suggests?
Definitely! It changed my life. My salary increased, I got national recognition and got to play with the best. If you do well, you get more opportunities. It was after my performance in the IPL that I got to play in the Ranji Trophy.

Q. What does it take to have a long career in sport?
They say you have to train your body, but I was always training my mind. If I send it a message, like I want to run for an hour, then I will do it. Even if I am tired, I focus and push myself. I don't let anything stop me.

Q. How much has Rahul Dravid shaped the player you are today?
Whatever I am right now is because of him. When I went for selection trials for Rajasthan Royals, everyone was asking my age. He, however, the team captain then, never did. I bowled and fielded wherever he wanted me to and I got selected. It was a dream to be in the same dressing room as him. The Indian cricket team is in great hands. ■

–with Suhani Singh